was appointed to interpret the book for me' – and present a page that very day. He managed, and Akbar approved. When the book was done, it was 'graciously accepted, and placed in the Library'. However, as the unfamiliar – and, in Badauni's eyes, unfit – texts followed one after the other, the translator began to lose heart. In the *Atharban* (Atharva Veda), Badauni was pleased to discover Islamic elements – 'I found that a Hindu under certain circumstances may eat cow-flesh; and also that Hindus bury their dead, but do not burn them.' The Ramayana, he thought, might be compared to 'the Shahnama, and the stories of Amir Hamzah'. But the Mahabharata?
'[P]uerile absurdities!' cried Badauni. 'But such is my fate, to be employed on such works.'

The trouble wasn't only that Badauni couldn't accept his fate, but that his talent wouldn't let him escape it. Many, many years later, he was trying for an appointment in the Ajmer dargah, but Akbar was loath to let his translator go. '[W]henever I give him anything to translate,' the emperor said, 'he always writes what is very pleasing to me, I do not wish that he should be separated from me'. Badauni was working on some more 'Hindu lies', this time the *Bahr ul-Asmar* ('Sea of Tales', possibly the *Rajatarangini*) and Akbar summoned him to his bedroom to tell him some of its stories. All night long, Badauni regaled the emperor, like Akbar's own Scheherazade. Afterwards, Akbar ordered him to finish the work, and gave him 10,000 tankahs and a horse. None of this did anything to alleviate Badauni's gloom – he only hoped he would finish in two or three months and then die.[21]

Abul Fazl, on the other hand – the shy student who only wanted to bury himself in his books – was having a whale of a time. His happiness, and Akbar's growing affection for him, derived greatly – as Badauni saw it – from Abul Fazl's eager embrace of radical or heretical ideas, and a corresponding willingness to bait the old guard – poor Makhdum-ul-Mulk, his father's one-time nemesis, amongst them. Abul Fazl did not hesitate 'in putting them to shame', writes Badauni, 'at which the Emperor was pleased'.

Baited and battered, it seems these high-ranking scholars sent Abul Fazl a pleading message, 'Why are you always falling foul of us?' Abul Fazl's answer was as cryptic as he was unmoved. 'The fact of the matter', he is